JEREMY LIGHTSMITH

For over 25 years, I've been a hands-on technical leader — writing production code, making architecture calls, building teams, and shaping the organizational structures that let engineering orgs deliver at their best.

As a fractional CTO, I bring something rare: the technical depth to work directly with your engineers, the leadership experience to set and hold a coherent technical direction, and the process fluency to build a team that can execute. I'm as effective writing code as I am in a board conversation or a difficult team retrospective. I work best with Series A/B companies that have a technical team but no senior technical leader.

TECHNICAL

Elixir / Phoenix
Ruby + Rails
React + Redux
JavaScript
LLMs + AI integration
Clojure
C# / Java

LEADERSHIP

Technical Strategy
Enterprise Architecture
Team Building
Executive Coaching
Lean + Kanban
Agile / XP / TDD
Facilitation
Systems Thinking

EDUCATION

University of Southern California
BS in Computer Science

Hudson Coaching Institute
Santa Barbara, CA
ICF Leadership Coaching
(graduation: early 2027)

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SELECTED ENGAGEMENTS

- **Built and ran an engineering org from zero** — As founder/CTO/CEO of Transparent Classroom, made every technical and organizational decision: stack, architecture, hiring, process, culture. Grew to a 14-person self-managed team with $3M ARR, consistently outperforming 100-person competitors.
- **Product discovery & team enablement** — Built the Nordstrom Innovation Lab's process from scratch — Lean Startup, Liberating Structures, Design Thinking — and used it to build and validate products at speed. Then took the toolkit outside the lab: ran workshops with buyer teams, coached senior leaders, and left people able to run the process themselves.
- **Lean transformation + delivery system design** — Led a value stream mapping intervention at a client org where priorities were unclear and work was batching up. Made the waste visible, gave leadership a shared language for fixing it, and built a pull-based management system that changed how work flowed day-to-day.
- **Enterprise architecture & adoption** — I have led architecture design across several organizations and coached teams on evolutionary architecture — from early days of agile through the AI era.
- **Technical leadership while pivoting** — Anchored a delivery team on Mechanical Orchard's largest client engagement: set technical direction, led LLM adoption into the team's workflow, and designed a custom job wall system that became the company's primary tool for visualizing and communicating delivery as we continued to pivot.
- **Strategic rewrite decision & execution** — At TalentWall, assessed an unstable Ruby+Angular codebase and led the direction and execution of a full rewrite to Elixir+LiveView — while simultaneously hardening the existing system to support a growing business. On time, no business disruption.

EXPERIENCE

Mechanical Orchard — 2023 - 2026

ANCHOR / LEAD DEVELOPER (Elixir / LLMs / Python)

Anchored multiple delivery and tools teams as we learned how to use AI to modernize mainframes at Fortune 500 clients.

Crosschq — 2021 - 2023

LEAD DEVELOPER (Elixir)

Led a dev team at this recruiting pipeline visualization and analytics company and rewrote the core engine.

Transparent Classroom — 2012 - 2021

FOUNDER / CEO / CTO (Ruby / JS)

As CTO, chose the stack, designed the architecture, and grew the engineering team — while simultaneously running the company as CEO into industry-leader for Montessori schools: 300K+ children, ~2,000 schools, 100 countries.

Outpace Systems, Inc — 2014 - 2016

TEAM LEAD / DEVELOPER (Clojure)

Led the team on the rules engine at the heart of this 60-person distributed startup.

Nordstrom Innovation Lab
2011 - 2013

COACH / DEVELOPER (Ruby / JS)

Helped design, build, and run the lab to deliver innovation to Nordstrom as a whole and change the way Nordstrom approaches work.

Lightsmith Consulting LLC
2009 - 2013

COACH / CONSULTANT

Agile and lean consulting, helping organizations transform and move toward high-performing teams.

Pivotal Labs
2007 - 2009

ANCHOR / CLIENT PRINCIPAL (Ruby)

On-demand project teams for early stage startups; led teams and managed scope and client relationships.

ThoughtWorks Inc.
2000 - 2007

COACH / DEVELOPER / FACILITATOR (Java / C# / Ruby)

Coach, developer, and facilitator across many projects. Led multi-million dollar projects.

COMMUNITY & OTHER WORK

Retreat of TBD + Chautauqua
2012 - present

CO-FOUNDER / OPEN SPACE FACILITATOR

Human Systems Dynamics Institute
2018 - 2020

BOARD MEMBER

Agile Open Northwest
2015 - 2020

BOARD MEMBER / OPEN SPACE FACILITATOR

Lighthouse Montessori School
2008 - present

CO-FOUNDER / BOARD CHAIR

References available upon request